

The 6:15

FRIDAY · SEPTEMBER 25, 2026

NO. 19

THE BOARD

CALENDAR (NEXT 10 DAYS)

Today	Final Sept. UMich consumer sentiment, 10:00a ET — prelim (Sept. 11) was 47.8, second-lowest on record, vs. 51.0 expected, 4.6% year-ahead inflation expectations [DEVELOPING] . Durable goods orders 8:30a ET, consensus -0.3%/+0.6% core. Day two of the Trump-Xi state visit. Northwestern at No. 5 Indiana, 8:00p ET (FOX One) — see Sports.
Mon 9/28	Dallas Fed manufacturing index, 10:30a ET. First orbital Starship-Super Heavy v3 flight, 26 Starlink V3 sats — first operational Starship payload [NEW/scheduled, not reconfirmed] .
Tue 9/29	JOLTS; Case-Shiller home prices. Yankees host the AL Wild Card Series opener [carried from issue No. 17, not re-verified] .
Wed 9/30	August PCE price index (BEA), 8:30a ET — first inflation read since the Sept. 16 hike.
Thu 10/1	Challenger job cuts 5:30a; initial claims 8:30a; S&P Global/ISM mfg. PMIs 9:45a/10:00a. Nike FQ1 2027 earnings after the close (~4:15p ET); consensus ~\$0.27 EPS / \$11.0-11.4B rev. (Nasdaq/CNBC).
Fri 10/2	September jobs report (BLS).
Sat 10/4	OPEC+ 68th JMMC meeting.

FOMC next meets Oct. 27-28; hike-odds trackers diverge sharply this run — CME FedWatch 73% (Sept. 23) vs. other trackers 54%-65%. Earnings cluster wk. of 9/28-10/2 (Broadcom, Adobe, Oracle, Micron, Costco, Accenture, Dell, HPE, others) carried from issue No. 18, not re-verified this run.

METRICS · ET UNLESS NOTED, AS RETRIEVED THIS RUN

Oil	Divergent: Brent settled Thu \$106.60 (+3.4% d/d), intraday high just over \$108 before easing on the phased-deal report. WTI \$94.76-\$95.25 Thu (+2.82% one tracker) — implies an unusually wide ~\$11-12
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Brent-WTI spread, not reconciled against a second NYMEX settle **[flag]**.

Rates	10Y hit 5.223% intraday Thu, highest since June 2007; a same-day tracker separately shows 5.12% — divergent. 30Y hit 5.501% Thu, highest since June 2004; other Thu reads 5.44%-5.46%. 2Y 4.90% (Tue) vs. 4.71% (Forbes, same day) — stale and divergent.
Vol/FX/gold	DXY 101.21 (Thu close, -0.02%). VIX 15.18 (Thu close). Gold \$4,250.85-\$4,273.80 (Thu, sources vary), down from issue No. 18's \$4,308-\$4,338 range.
Equities	Thu close: Dow 51,349.98 (-0.3%/-161.61pts); S&P 500 7,704.13 (flat, -1.90pts); Nasdaq Comp. 26,939.37 (flat, +3.34pts). Futures Fri AM: higher, led by AKAM (+20%+ premarket, Anthropic deal) and GOOGL (SpaceX AI-chip JV report), despite the 10Y near 2007 highs.
Asia/Europe/gas	Asia (Fri close): Nikkei 66,347 (+1.27%); Hang Seng 24,307 (-1.83%); ASX -0.6%; China/Korea/Taiwan closed. Europe (Thu close): FTSE +0.1%; DAX -0.2%; CAC -0.3%. Retail gas: AAA \$4.4825/gal natl. avg (Thu), up from \$4.4744 (Wed) — AAA's highest-ever for this point in the year.

Crude: ICE Brent/NYMEX WTI front-month trackers. Rates: Fed H.15/CME-style trackers.
Equities: exchange closes/CNBC-style quote pages.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Diplomacy	US and Iranian negotiators exploring a phased deal in New York (UNGA sidelines, Qatar-mediated): Iran reopens the strait in exchange for the US lifting its naval blockade of Iranian ports; a senior Iranian official called it "the most realistic path forward" (Reuters). Dennis Ross (former US negotiator) put deal odds this week at ~30% [NEW, multi-sourced] .
Transits	Kepler prelim Fri: 13 crossings vs. an 85/day pre-crisis baseline — up from PortWatch's 8/day (Sept. 13) and 6/day (Sept. 6), still ~15% of normal. Different vendor/window; not reconciled against PortWatch.
Dark tankers/AIS	No fresher count this run; the ~80% (two-week window) vs. ~57% (full conflict period) split from issue No. 18 carries unrefreshed [continuity] .

War-risk premia

Reconfirmed this run at 7.5%-10% of hull value (~\$21M on a 270,000-tonne tanker at peak tension); unchanged from issues No. 16-18.

Transit counts, dark-fleet share and hull-value premia measure different things over different windows — reported side by side, never netted or averaged.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees

Beat Tampa Bay 6-4 Thursday (Wells HR No. 13, Lombard Jr. HR No. 6; Hanner the win) — 92-67 through Thursday by our count — see Sports.

Knicks

NBA (not the team) published New York's preseason slate — five games Oct. 5-15, opening at Philadelphia; rookie Tyler Nickel still unsigned.

Northwestern

No moves since Saturday's win; at No. 5 Indiana tonight, 8:00p ET.

LEAD

OIL WHIPSAWS ON HORMUZ

A Houthi missile salvo aimed at the port absorbing Aramco's Hormuz bypass collides with a US-Iran phased-deal trial balloon, whipsawing oil in a single session

The most important oil story of the last 24 hours isn't one story — it's two contradictory ones landing on the same tape within hours of each other. Thursday morning, the Saudi-led coalition said it intercepted six Houthi ballistic missiles aimed at Yanbu, the Red Sea port that has absorbed Saudi Arabia's entire strategy for routing crude around the Strait of Hormuz since the East-West "Petroline" pipeline restarted Sept. 22. The Houthis later claimed they had struck "a sensitive target" in Riyadh and Aramco facilities specifically at Yanbu; Saudi authorities reported no damage or casualties, and civil-defense alerts covering Mecca, Tabuk, Jeddah, Yanbu and Taif were lifted within hours. [fact] Almost simultaneously, Reuters and

Bloomberg reported that US and Iranian negotiators in New York are exploring a phased arrangement — Tehran reopens the strait to navigation in exchange for Washington lifting its naval blockade of Iranian ports — with a senior Iranian official calling it the most realistic path forward. [fact] Oil spiked to just over \$108 a barrel intraday on the combination of the attack and a separate report that Asian refiners are importing crude at the fastest pace since the war began, then gave back roughly half those gains once the phased-deal story broke, settling Brent at \$106.60, up 3.4% on the day. [fact]

The mechanism worth sitting with is the target selection, not just the price move. Markets had been treating the Petrolina restart as the release valve on Hormuz risk — a way for roughly 4 million barrels a day of Saudi crude to reach tankers without transiting the strait at all, decoupling at least part of global supply from the blockade. A strike aimed at the exact port that bypass discharges into, whether or not it does physical damage, is a direct challenge to that thesis: it signals the Houthis can extend pressure to the alternative route, not just the strait itself. [read] That the attack failed to land doesn't fully neutralize the signal — war-risk premia held steady this run at 7.5%-10% of hull value rather than spiking further, suggesting the market is for now treating Thursday as a near-miss rather than a regime change. [fact/read] But it sits awkwardly next to the same day's diplomatic story, which points the opposite direction: an actual reduction in blockade risk, not an escalation of it. Two signals, on the same route, in the same 24 hours, pulling oil in opposite directions — which is exactly what a \$108-to-\$106.60 round trip looks like on a chart. [read]

The knock-on read for a portfolio: none of this yet shows up in the numbers that would confirm a real change in physical supply.

Kepler's preliminary strait-transit count ticked up to 13 crossings Friday from the high-single-digits seen earlier in September — better, but still roughly 15% of the 85-a-day pre-crisis baseline, and not corroborated yet by PortWatch's own slower-updating series (see Hormuz counters). Dennis Ross, who has negotiated this region before, put the odds of an actual deal this week at only about 30%. [fact] That combination — a real but unconfirmed uptick in traffic, a credible but long-shot diplomatic track, and a demonstrated willingness by the Houthis to test the alternative route — argues for treating Thursday's price relief as provisional rather than a turn. [read] It also lands at an inconvenient moment for the inflation debate: crude near a post-attack high going into next Wednesday's August PCE print gives the Fed one more input pointing toward the hawkish side of an already-hawkish September, with retail gasoline already at AAA's highest-ever level for this point in the calendar year. [read] The bond market's separate rout — the 10-year brushing a 2007 high and the 30-year a 2004 high this week — was already pricing sticky inflation before Thursday's oil action; a crude market that can't decide between escalation and de-escalation in the same session does nothing to resolve that question one way or the other. [read]

POLITICS

Day two of Xi Jinping's Washington visit continues Friday after Thursday's roughly three-hour bilateral and state dinner; the concrete deliverable so far is the two-month extension of the US-China trade truce, pushing the expiration from mid-November to Jan. 10, 2027 — the US holds tariffs steady and China continues allowing rare-earth magnet exports, with US officials separately weighing narrow tariff cuts on "non-strategic" goods like fireworks and low-end

consumer products. [fact] The original truce dates to an October 2025 agreement struck in South Korea; Thursday's extension removes a near-term tariff-snapback risk without resolving the underlying rare-earth, tariff and technology-control disputes it merely pauses. [fact/read] Anticipated announcements on broader tariff cuts and a new AI communication channel had not materialized as of Thursday evening; Hong Kong-listed Chinese stocks fell on the summit day, which several outlets read as traders pricing a lack of substantive progress. [read] No update was located this run on the CNN/Politico/MS NOW White House access restriction flagged in issue No. 17; it was not re-researched this cycle. [continuity]

ECONOMICS

The University of Michigan's preliminary September sentiment reading — 47.8, second-lowest since the survey's 1952 start, against 51.0 expected — sits awkwardly next to August retail sales (+1.2% m/m, +6.0% y/y) and a labor market still adding jobs at a 4.1% unemployment rate; today's 10:00a ET final print is the test of whether that gap narrows or widens. [fact] Year-ahead inflation expectations in the preliminary read rose to 4.6%, the highest since June, which is the more Fed-relevant number given next Wednesday's PCE print. [fact] Hike-odds trackers disagree by more than the Fed itself typically leaves ambiguous this close to a meeting — CME's FedWatch read 73% for an October hike as of Tuesday, while at least two other trackers checked this run sit between 54% and 65% — a spread that likely reflects how quickly each recalculates off intraday Fed-speak and data, including this week's comments from Fed Governor Barr reiterating support for the September hike. [flag] The Fed's own September dot plot still shows 16 of 18 participants projecting at least one more 2026 hike.

BUSINESS

Saudi Aramco's East-West pipeline is running at a reduced rate after Tuesday's restart, with full restoration of its 7 million-bpd nameplate capacity — versus the roughly 4 million bpd needed just to cover Saudi refining plus a modest export margin — expected to take up to six weeks while three drone-damaged pumping stations are rebuilt. [fact] Akamai shares surged more than 20% in premarket trading Friday after Anthropic signed an \$11.6 billion, seven-year deal for Akamai's CPU infrastructure, with expansion options that could bring total deal value to roughly \$20 billion. [fact] Alphabet shares also ticked higher premarket on reports of a joint venture with SpaceX to begin testing Google's custom AI chips in orbit. [fact] Nike reports fiscal Q1 FY2027 results after Thursday's close (Oct. 1, ~4:15p ET), with consensus around \$0.27 EPS on \$11.0B-\$11.4B revenue (Nasdaq/CNBC) — the first of next week's large-cap earnings cluster to report.

TECHNOLOGY

Anthropic released Claude Opus 5.5 on Sept. 22, positioned for long-running agentic coding and knowledge work; OpenAI released GPT-6 Sol the same day, a cheaper, faster sibling to GPT-6 Astra aimed at everyday professional and coding use rather than frontier research tasks. [fact] The Financial Times reported insiders discussing a fresh OpenAI funding round that could value the company near \$1.2 trillion, which would leapfrog Anthropic's \$965 billion post-money valuation from its \$65 billion May Series H — that round briefly made Anthropic the world's most valuable private company before OpenAI's own \$122 billion round in March priced it at \$852 billion. [fact/flag — round unconfirmed by either company this run] Both companies are now releasing model updates roughly in lockstep, within days of each other, a cadence that has held for most of 2026 and leaves little room for either lab to claim a durable capability lead from a single release. [read] The Akamai-Anthropic infrastructure deal (see Business) and the reported Alphabet-SpaceX orbital chip-testing venture are both, in effect, AI-capacity stories arriving the same week as the funding chatter — compute buildout and compute financing moving in parallel. [read]

GEOPOLITICS

Beyond the trade-truce extension (see Politics), Trump and Xi's stated agenda for the two-day visit runs through Taiwan, AI, Iran and the South China Sea; no deliverable was reported on any of the last three as of Thursday evening, and Trump has previously called potential Taiwan arms sales "a very good negotiating chip," a framing that keeps that file open heading into day two. [fact/read]

OPEC+'s next scheduled checkpoint is the 68th JMMC meeting Oct. 4 — the first opportunity for the group to react formally to this week's oil whipsaw and to any confirmed progress on the US-Iran track. [fact] No fresh Ukraine development was located this run beyond what issue No. 17 already carried; that thread was not re-searched this cycle. [continuity]

IRAN & HORMUZ

The New York channel described in the Lead is the most concrete diplomatic movement since the three-hour Sept. 22 Witkoff-Kushner-Araghchi meeting covered in issue No. 18 — this week's reporting adds the specific proposed trade (navigation for blockade relief) and a rare on-record Iranian assessment that it's realistic, though Dennis Ross's 30% odds this week is a reminder that "realistic" and "likely" aren't the same thing. [read] Kepler's 13-crossing Friday count and the still-unreconciled PortWatch series (6-8/day through mid-September) both point the same direction — a slow uptick, not a reopening — which is consistent with a negotiation still in progress rather than concluded. [read] The dark-tanker/AIS split from issue No. 18 (roughly 80% two-week vs. 57% full-period AIS-off) was not refreshed this run and should be treated as stale. [continuity] War-risk premia holding at 7.5%-10% of hull value through Thursday's Yanbu attack, rather than spiking, is itself informative: underwriters priced Thursday as contained. [read] Net read for the week ahead: this is a market pricing a wide range of outcomes — from the Petrolina bypass being tested by further strikes to an actual phased strait reopening — without enough confirmed data yet to collapse that range to a single scenario before the Oct. 4 JMMC and the Oct. 27-28 FOMC give it more to work with. [read]

SPORTS

Yankees	Beat Tampa Bay 6-4 Thursday at Yankee Stadium (Wells HR No. 13, Lombard Jr. HR No. 6; Hanner W). 92-67 through Thursday by our game-log count; clinched a playoff berth Sept. 14; hosts the AL Wild Card Series opener Tue. 9/29 (date not re-verified this run).
Knicks	No reported moves in the last 24 hours; NBA-published preseason schedule opens Oct. 5 at Philadelphia. Defending NBA champions; rookie Tyler Nickel still unsigned.
Northwestern	2-0, no game since Saturday's 41-7 win over Colorado. At No. 5 Indiana tonight, 8:00p ET (FOX One); a 21.5-point underdog against the reigning national champions.

Continuity. Not refreshed this run: Ukraine/Sumy developments, the Russia sanctions-bill signing status, the Salalah multilateral-meeting reschedule, the CNN/Politico/MS NOW White House access restriction, and the Hormuz dark-tanker/AIS split (carried from issue No. 18). Watch for next issue: today's final UMich sentiment print and whether it confirms or narrows the preliminary 47.8 collapse; whether Friday's Kepler transit uptick is corroborated by PortWatch's own count; any confirmation of an actual US-Iran phased agreement versus continued talks; and whether Thursday's Brent/WTI and 10Y/30Y source divergences resolve to single settles by Monday.

Unverified figures are marked in red: the Brent/WTI settle pair and implied spread, the 10Y/30Y/2Y yield readings (each diverging by source), European closes, the Wild Card Series exact date, Nike's earnings consensus, the OpenAI \$1.2T funding round, and the earnings-cluster dates for the week of 9/28. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.